

RMPA ABSTRACT

Marriage is often linked to better physical health, yet these benefits depend heavily on the quality of the relationship (Reyes et al., 2025). Additionally, for many young couples, marriage also alters social networks. Longitudinal data suggest that spouses' friendship networks decline over time, reducing ties outside the marriage and potentially limiting sources of outside support (Haggerty et al., 2023). These changes in social support may differentially affect men and women, influencing their subjective experiences of loneliness and well-being. This research strives to illuminate some of these gender-specific issues in marital contexts.

Additionally, men appear to derive more well-being gains from being married, with some evidence questioning whether women benefit as strongly (Reyes et al., 2025). Religiosity and spirituality are generally associated with better mental health, offering modest stress-buffering benefits; though these associations vary, many studies report lower depression and greater well-being among more religious/spiritual individuals (Lucchetti et al., 2021). Gender differences in loneliness are not just about who is lonelier, but how loneliness varies by age, culture, and measurement.

Recent work has highlighted loneliness and its relevance to young adults, including gender-specific associations related to social media use (Wright et al., 2018). In their study of 579 college students, Wright and colleagues found that loneliness increased with daily social media usage, with women consistently reporting greater loneliness with increased social media use compared with men. These findings suggest that men and women may experience distinct differences in loneliness, emphasizing the need for gender-sensitive approaches.

Indeed, social media use is consistently linked to negative psychological outcomes, including greater loneliness and increased depressive symptoms (Wright et al., 2018; Wright et

al., 2020; Wright et al., 2021). Within intimate relationships such as marriage, the use of social media raises the issue of phubbing—the act of "phone snubbing," or ignoring one's partner by focusing on a mobile device—resulting in the reduction of quality time. This study addresses gender differences in social media and the disparities in how men and women utilize social media (e.g., maintenance vs. entertainment, Ewing et al., 2023). Prior research shows that while intimate relationships can deter loneliness by fulfilling the need to belong, feelings of disconnection persist when closeness is lacking (Mund, 2022). Marriage itself does not guarantee protection from loneliness; strained or ambivalent relationships are linked to greater isolation compared to supportive ones (Hsieh & Hawkley, 2018).

Understanding gender differences in marital loneliness is notable, as these patterns shape mental health, social support networks, and long-term relationship outcomes, particularly for young adults navigating the early years of marriage. Satisfaction in marriage influences the well-being of the participants; however, these benefits may not be experienced equally between men and women. Understanding these patterns in young marriages can shape long-term relational and mental health trajectories and inform interventions to support gender-sensitive well-being (Wickrama, 2020).

We propose three hypotheses: 1) that religious married women would experience higher levels of loneliness compared with religious married men, consistent with prior findings on gender differences. 2) that greater amounts of screen time would be associated with increased loneliness among married women, as high levels of social media usage may limit opportunities for meaningful in-person interaction or contribute to social comparison processes that may heighten feelings of isolation. 3) that the association between increased social media use would lead to increased loneliness for married women.

Following IRB approval, students from Brigham Young University, Brigham Young University-Idaho, and Brigham Young University-Hawaii were given an online questionnaire. The eligibility criteria were: married, between the ages of 18 and 30, enrolled in one of the BYU schools (BYU-Provo, BYU-Idaho, BYU-Hawaii), be an English speaker, and married less than 5 years. A total of 199 responses were collected, the average age was 23.24, ($SD=1.83$). Women made up 51% of the sample, and the majority were White (83.4%) with most indicating no children (91.6%).

Independent-samples t-tests were conducted to examine differences between men and women in congruence with our hypotheses. Results indicated a significant difference in positive mood, $t(197) = 2.75, p = .007$, with married women reporting higher overall mood levels. Loneliness also differed significantly between groups, $t(197) = 2.24, p = .026$, indicating greater perceived loneliness in married women. Additionally, a significant difference emerged for social media use, $t(197) = -2.65, p = .008$, suggesting lower social media use among married men. These findings support our hypotheses that religious married women report higher loneliness and screen time scores compared to religious married men.

Our study contributes to the literature by demonstrating increased feelings of loneliness and increased social media use among young married women at a religious institution compared to men, despite the assumption that marriage provides protective benefits (Strohschein, 2016). The finding that religious married women reported higher loneliness and social media use than men aligns with prior work suggesting women often report greater loneliness (Barreto et al., 2021). This underscores the need for gender-sensitive models of relational well-being since marital status alone does not guarantee protection from loneliness (Hsieh & Hawkey, 2018). We suggest future research examining marital loneliness in relation to partner screen time use, and

extending current knowledge on how social media use may impact high-commitment relationships. Given that social media and screen time continue to play a significant role in the daily lives of young married students, further research is needed to better understand these dynamics.

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